Margaret Avery, MPA

Economic & Community Development Professional

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Kalamazoo, MI, 49007

Overview

Economic development and public-sector professional with extensive expertise in managing diverse teams, cultivating collaborative partnerships, and expanding programs to meet the needs of underserved communities. Proven success supporting business development, infrastructure investment, and site readiness initiatives through strategic analysis and multi-source funding. Recognized for building cross-sector partnerships, managing multi-stakeholder projects, and translating community vision into implementable development outcomes.

Professional Experience

Policy Analyst & Grant Writer, Albion, MI
Interim Director April 2023 – Current
Albion Economic Development Corporation

- Lead and coordinated economic development initiatives, supporting industrial, commercial, and community redevelopment projects from concept to implementation.
- Managed and advanced site readiness efforts, including environmental due diligence, infrastructure planning, land assembly analysis, and redevelopment feasibility for publicly owned strategic parcels.
- Served as the primary liaison between the AEDC, City of Albion, Calhoun County, developers, utilities, and state agencies to align local priorities with regional and state economic development strategies.
- Developed and managed complex funding strategies and capital stacks for economic development projects, securing and administering over $20 million in public and private investment for infrastructure, housing, and business development initiatives.
- Conducted economic, market, and financial analyses to support redevelopment planning, property disposition strategies, and long-term economic growth goals.
- Provided strategic guidance to AEDC leadership on board policy, funding opportunities, and project prioritization to advance the organization's economic development mission.
- Designed, implemented, and managed initiatives like the Entrepreneur Coaching Program, targeting minority-owned business development and addressing systemic barriers to economic success.
- Acted as interim director during leadership transitions, ensuring continuity of economic development projects, funding compliance, and stakeholder coordination.
- Lead many of the AEDC's development priorities, including industrial development, commercial revitalization, and housing supply expansion.
- Represented AEDC in meetings with regional economic development organizations, state departments, and funding partners.

Director of Community Advocacy Programs, Michigan Nov. 2021 – Current
Equality Michigan

- Expanded the Advocacy for Community Empowerment (ACE) department, increasing service reach in rural communities and developing innovative educational initiatives to address LGBTQ+ advocacy needs.
- Developed and maintained additional collaborative partnerships while developing & implementing new programs for legal, healthcare, and housing assistance.
- Directed and supported a diverse team of staff, volunteers, and interns, fostering a collaborative and inclusive work environment to deliver high-impact advocacy services.
- Secured funding and partnerships to develop & launch new programs, such as first/last month's rent assistance, family-friendly drag events, and LGBTQ+ youth book clubs, strengthening community engagement.
- Managed compliance with federal funding requirements, including the preparation and submission of detailed grant applications and reports under the Victim of Crime Act (VOCA).

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- Delivered high quality survivor-centered, trauma-informed intensive case management to victims/survivors; developing service plans to match individual needs utilizing a range of financial, medical, social, legal, and other services and resources based on participants needs, eligibility, and priorities.

Fund Development Director, Battle Creek, MI — Sept. 2022 – July 2025

Battle Creek Area Habitat for Humanity

- Revitalized Battle Creek Area Habitat for Humanity by securing critical funding when the organization faced closure, growing its financial stability and expanding operations to the highest level in a decade.
- Managed donor stewardship programs, ensuring regular communication and engagement with donors to maintain long-term relationships.
- Prepared compelling grant proposals, securing $3+ million in funding from local, regional, and national foundations, corporations, and government agencies.
- Led and managed fundraising initiatives, increasing revenue by over 200% to support capacity, programs, and services.
- Developed the strategic plan for 2024-2029 while implementing evaluation efforts, outreach updates, and funding plans.
- Closely collaborated with the Board of Directors to set fundraising goals and align them with organizational priorities.

Education

Grand Valley State University, Grand Rapids, MI
Graduate Degree- MPA
Policy Analysis, Advocacy, Evaluation

Grand Valley State University, Allendale, MI
Bachelor of Science
Political Science, Legal Studies, and Women, Gender, and Sexuality Studies

Skills

Professionals Skills: Advocacy & Outreach | Collaborative Problem-Solving | Stakeholder Engagement | Public Speaking | Strategic Planning | Budget Management | Leadership Development

Technical Skills: Policy Analysis | Grant Writing | Data Analysis | Project Management | Training Development | Resource Management | Evaluation Planning